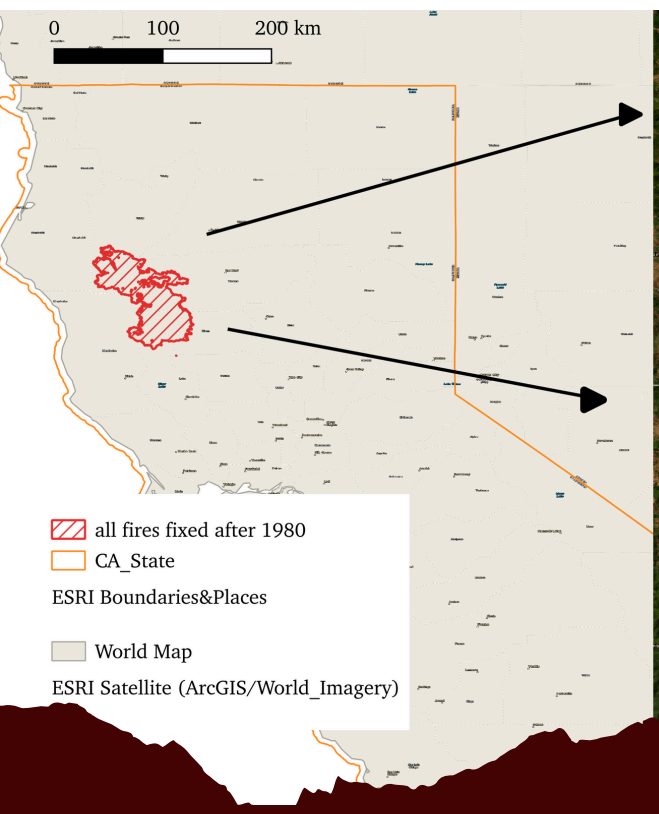
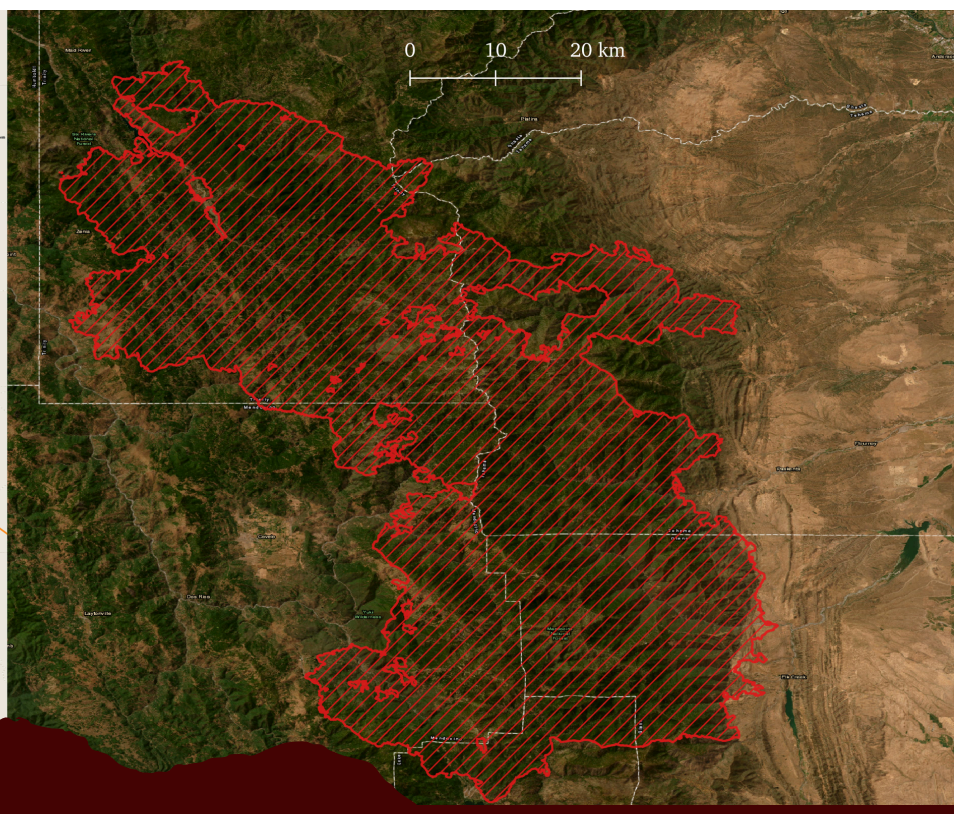
August Complex Fire

The August Complex Fire of 2020, California's largest wildfire, burned over 1 million acres, merging 38 lightning-sparked fires into the state's first recorded "gigafire."





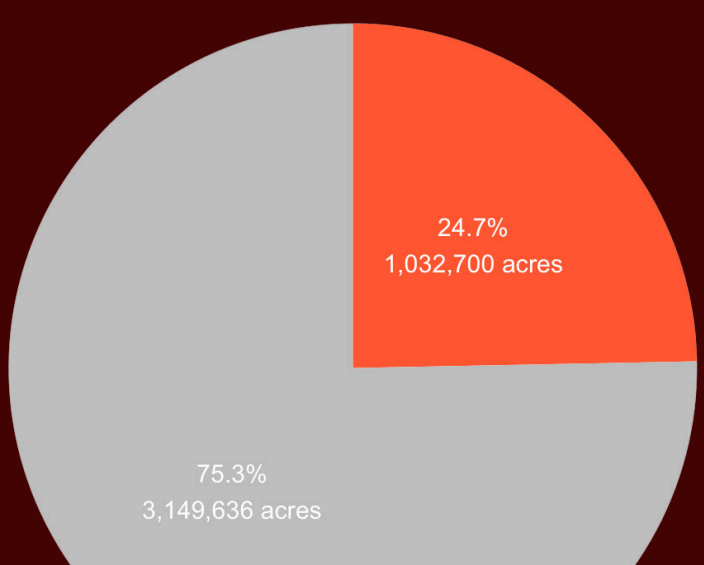
August 16-17
Lightning Ignition
Lightning sparks 38 separate fires.

August 30
Fires Merge
Multiple fires combine into one.

September 10
Complex Expands
Merges into record-breaking size.

October
Gigafire Declared
Surpasses 1 million acres burned

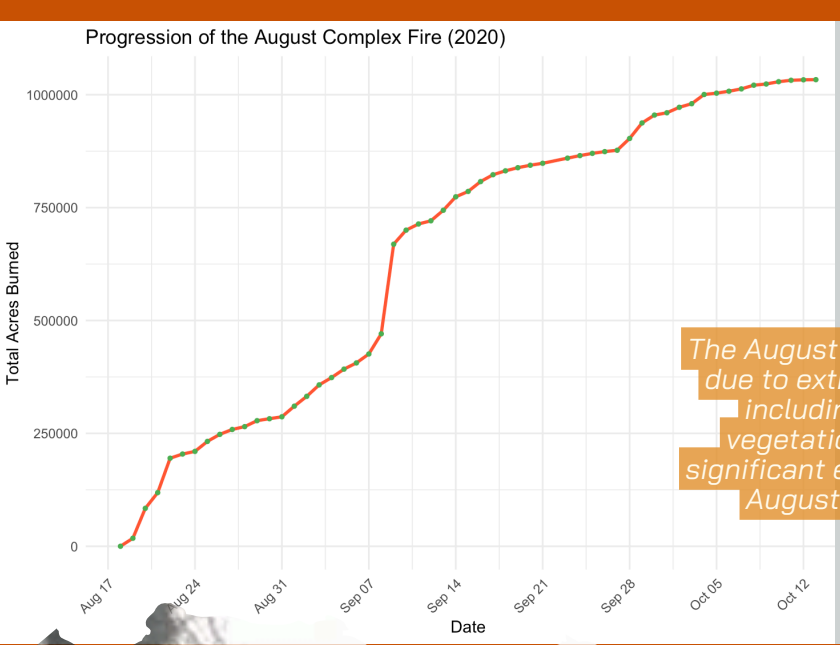
November 12
Contained
Fire fully controlled after months.



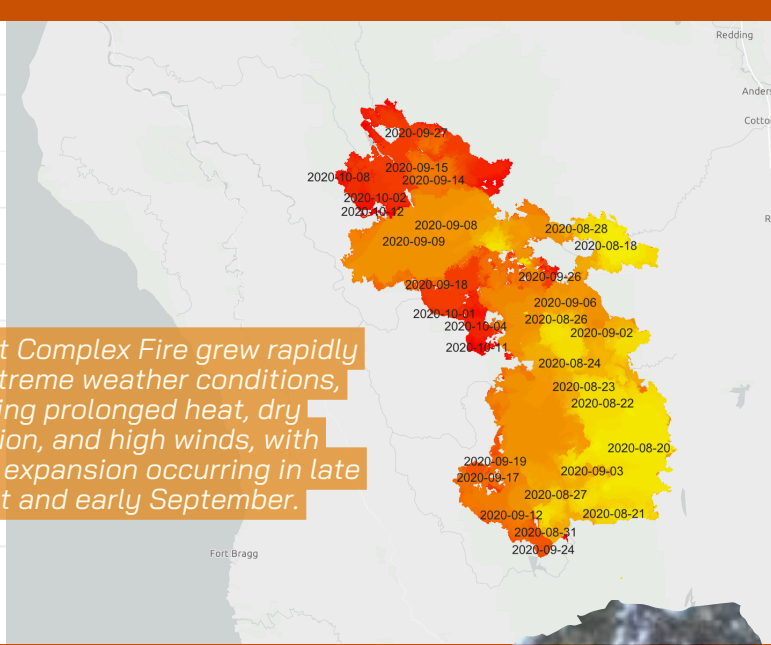
Size of August Complex Relative to All other Fires in California During 2020 (August Complex in Orange)

Deaths: 1 firefighter
Non-fatal injuries: 2 firefighte
Structures destroyed: 935
Damage: $320 million (USD)

Firefighters faced unprecedented challenges due to the fire's vast scale and rapid spread. A U.S. Forest Service official noted, "It is huge... it's big, very big," highlighting the enormity of the task.



The August Complex Fire grew rapidly due to extreme weather conditions, including prolonged heat, dry vegetation, and high winds, with significant expansion occurring in late August and early September.



August fire burned 1,032,648 acres about 1% of California's 100 million acres of land, an area larger than the state of Rhode Island.